“There was something inside of me that felt very proud of that work”:

The power of aesthetic experiences in secondary literacy education

Anne Crampton

Curriculum & Instruction

COLLEGE OF EDUCATION
+ HUMAN DEVELOPMENT

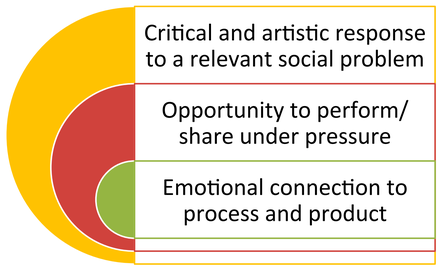
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Introduction

Abstract

We talk about “meaning making” as one of the central tasks of literacy learning, but what is it, and how does it occur? My study suggests that powerful experiences with meaning making in literacy classrooms, and indeed, in school itself, have to do with expression and connection, with aesthetics and love. My interest lies in theorizing these broad abstractions and then trying to see what they look like in everyday urban classrooms. Leaving aside love, for now, I examine some of the artifacts, field notes, and interview data from an ethnographic study in order to highlight how aesthetic experiences impacted students in a racially and culturally diverse urban English-Language Arts high school class that called for the production of critical digital texts: photography, podcasts, and documentary films.



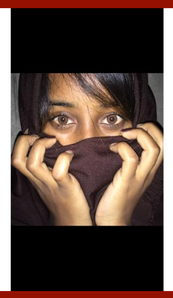


Background

Aesthetic experiences are extras in schools, invited inconsistently, and not reflected in reports of Annual Yearly Progress (AYP) even if they support student success in quantifiable ways (Peppler et al, 2014; President’s Committee, 2011). My understanding of aesthetic experiences in literacy education is not limited to recognized categories of art, but includes instances of being artistically engrossed in activity/work or creation with a “heightened vitality” (Dewey, 2005, p. 18), fully immersed while responding to and creating texts of all kinds.

With this understanding in mind, a sprawling theoretical and empirical field is consolidated into three overarching requirements for aesthetic experiences in academic settings: (1) critical and emotional reading of texts, (2) multimodal production that invites or attempts praxis/change, and (3) performance.

Frameworks:
- Dialogism
- Discourse studies
- Aesthetics



When I was new, in 2nd grade, a group of girls pulled my hijab off my head, and the pin that keeps it together went straight into my neck. It was bleeding and the teacher saw the blood but didn’t do anything. I couldn’t explain what had happened because I couldn’t speak English yet.

The Study

Setting Norris & Jones (2005), Scollon & Scollon (1998), and Wertsch (1998)
- Large, diverse urban high school
- 42 English & Social Studies students (grade 12)
- Focused on critical digital projects (photography, podcast, documentary film) on topics that challenged the status quo in some way, or educated the audience about a social issue

Data Sources

Data sources for the study include field notes and memos on classroom interactions, audio/video recordings and transcripts of discussions, individual interviews with participants, and student work.



Methodologies

Critical Ethnography

In this four-month critical ethnographic study, I sought to learn from student work, and the discourse and interaction patterns of both teacher and students as they engaged in several aesthetic and persuasive projects. As a participant-observer of interactions and cultures in the “multichanneled” social setting of a high school classroom (Emerson et al, 2011, p. 13), I continually worked against the positivist assumption that there is such a thing as a “classroom community,” singular, or even a collection of identifiable communities in a classroom space (Philip et al, 2013).

Critical Discourse Analysis (CDA) & Mediated Discourse Analysis (MDA)

I used CDA (Gee, 2011,2014) to analyze interview and interactional data, as well as MDA (Norris & Jones, 2005; Scollon & Scollon, 1998; Wertsch, 1998) to research social practices, social change, and agency, analyzing ways that interactions are mediated through objects, setting, relationship histories, and trajectories.

Findings

Production – Production of aesthetic multimodal projects involved multiple readings, perspective taking, vigorous argument about the desired product and possible impacts, resulting in the construction and championing of heteroglossic, persuasive texts



… it's what they intentionally chose through arguing and discussing and struggling to cut the interview, and the learning they experienced was in that struggle . . .

Performance – Students had awareness of and concern for their audiences throughout production: peers, family, informants/participants, and the general public (e.g. YouTube, SoundCloud). The teacher actively sought a larger audience for the projects, & was also the toughest and most consistent audience proxy.

“Hey, I **did** this. I **made** this.” **People are noticing it, arguing about it. It’s out there in the world.**

It was so hard. **Sharing that story was an accomplishment**. I just, yeah, that speech opened me up to being very uncomfortable, being comfortable in uncomfortable situations, so I’m very proud of that.

Heightened emotional experience – Students expressed an embodied connection to created texts, suggesting **links to identity & transformation.**

- **There was something inside of me that felt very proud of that work**.
- **It was something I made, with my hands**, and I’m not gonna forget that.
- You gotta **crunch it and grind it all out**, and then when it’s done, you’ve got this **final product**, you know, this golden egg, **and it feels super good, you feel super good about yourself**

Implications

Aesthetic experiences in this classroom—sustained emotional and critical production & performance--were not accidents. They came out of a challenging curriculum that was flexible (choice), and accessible (achievable) for all students. Participants were very clear about the difficulty and the pressure of performance, but all felt that they could, in the end, deliver. The success rate for the class was almost 100%.. Such **democratic aesthetic** experiences hold enormous potential for identity transformation toward not only “poet-citizens” (Ingalls, 2012) but collaborative, problem-solving, producer-citizens. And though the construction of complex aesthetic and persuasive texts requires **significant commitment of time and resources**, the data suggests that it was the ambition of the projects that made them powerful for students, many of whom felt the burden of meaning making for a school project for the first time in their 12 years of formal education.